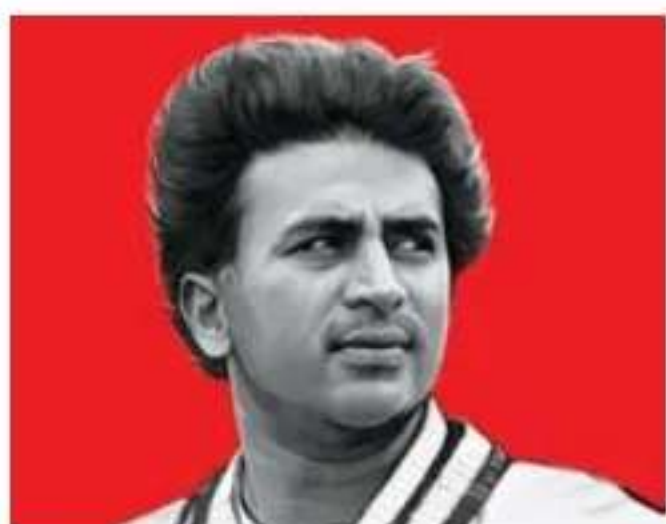




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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MAKING EXCUSES IS WHERE INDIA WILL WIN GOLD MEDALS EVERY SINGLE TIME

In the debate that followed Prakash Padukone's frank assessment of Lakshya Sen's Olympic podium miss, the **majority tended** to side with the current would-be champion and not the past-proven world champion.

Firstly, full disclosure.

In my humble opinion, and with the greatest respect to all other legends and champions from other sports, Prakash Padukone is the finest sportsperson that India has produced.

It's not just his incredible skill with which he conquered the badminton world time and again, but also his demeanour on and off the court that makes him so special in my eyes. Don't forget he did it at a time when a point could be won only on your serve and not as it is now where it can be won on the opponent's serve. At a time when the Danes and Chinese were unbeatable, Prakash was sending them packing, barely conceding seven to 10 points and occasionally none at all.

He has always been reticent and publicity-shy, and he goes about his life with as much quiet as his famous dribble at the net. Therefore, his frank comments after the badminton disappointment came as a surprise to so many who have known him over the years to keep his counsel and not say much. It also stirred up a debate where the majority tried, as is the modern way, to take the side of a current would-be champion and not that of a past-proven world champion. Making excuses is where our country will win gold medals every

single time, so the debate around his assessment was more about that than looking without tinted glasses at what he said.

And what did he say? He said that the players today get all the backing and facilities from their Federations and the government too. Therefore, they should take responsibility for their performances too. It was a point well-made and well-articulated too, without pointing fingers at anybody. Yet as it invariably happens in our country, which again is a champion at reading between so-called lines and imagining unintended poisoned arrows, we were quick to jump on him and denounce his comments rather than take the time to digest them and then come out with our comparatively uninformed views. If a player is not going to take responsibility for his performance, then who is? So what wrong did he say? Some say the timing was wrong, but it's always better to say that when a player is searching for excuses and support rather than later. Yes, he could have said that privately in the changing room, but believe me, nothing has more impact on a player than a public rebuke. If he has the heart of a champion, then he will want to make the person who rebuked him eat his words. Otherwise, he will continue to flatter only to deceive.